

C08 NEW PARENT SUPPORT | O (MAX : 3 PT)

Intent : Provide support for new parents to properly care for themselves and their children.

Summary : This WELL feature requires paid parental leave for primary and non-primary caregivers and supportive resources for parents returning to work.

Issue : Maintaining an infant's health before birth and during its first months of life is crucial to its long-term health.¹ Though infant care is a universal need, and most countries guarantee a minimum paid maternity leave, many do not offer paid partner leave, and when they do, it is often significantly shorter in duration.² Additionally, shorter and unpaid maternity leave may create barriers to accessing necessary healthcare such as postpartum healthcare, which is critical to receive in the first six weeks after childbirth to support new mothers' health.³

Solutions : The International Labor Organization recommends a minimum of 18 weeks of parental leave, with research indicating that 40 weeks of paid leave results in the greatest overall reduction of risk for low infant birth weight and infant mortality and results in higher rates of on-time infant immunizations.^{1,4,5} Longer paid parental leave and back-to-work coaching programs are associated with numerous health benefits, including higher rates of breastfeeding, reduced infant mortality and postpartum depression, decreased risk of low birthweight infants and higher paternal involvement, as well as higher long-term achievement for children, including reduced school drop-out rates and increased medical appointment attendance.^{4,6-10} Moreover, research shows that parental leave of up to a year (52 weeks) can help improve job continuity for women even years after childbirth.^{11,12} Research also demonstrates that fathers who take paid leave of at least two weeks are far more engaged in childcare nine months after birth.¹³ Organizational support for new parents can also increase employee retention and company loyalty.¹⁴

PART 1 OFFER NEW PARENT LEAVE (MAX : 3 PT)

For All Spaces:

1: Parental leave

A parental leave policy that meets the following requirements is available for all eligible employees:

- At least 40 weeks of parental leave is offered to the designated birthing parent and/or primary care giver.^{4,15} Of this, at least a portion must be paid at 75% or higher of the employee's full salary or wages and include benefits, per the table below.¹⁵
- Parental leave is offered to the non-primary caregiver, of which at least a portion is paid at 75% or higher of the employee's full salary or wages and including benefits, per the table below.^{13,16}
- Leave must be separate from other types of leave (e.g., sick leave, paid time off) and may be used consecutively or non-consecutively during any 12-month period during pregnancy or after birth or adoption.

Tier	Weeks of Paid Leave for the Birthing Parent and/or Primary Caregiver		Weeks of Paid Leave for Non-Primary Caregiver	Point Value
1	At least 12 weeks	AND	At least 2 weeks	1 point
2	At least 18 weeks ^{5,17}	AND	At least 3 weeks	2 points
3	At least 30 weeks ^{4,11}	AND	At least 4 weeks	3 points

2: Parental support policies

The project or organization offers a policy that provides at least two of the following services to help employees utilize and return from parental leave.^{4,6-9}

- At least one of the following upon returning from parental leave:
 - Part-time options (e.g., ramp back programs).
 - Work from home flexibility.
 - Flexible schedules.
- Communications (e.g., emails, modules, trainings) sent to expecting parents about the parental leave policies and resources, including guidance on the positive health impacts of parental leave.
- Coaching or counseling program, or other resources to help employees transition when returning from parental leave.
- Training for managers on how to work with employees to create a plan for parental leave and optimally support employees returning from parental leave.

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